

THE FUNCTIONAL FLOW OF HARMONY

Every piece of music follows the same narrative arc — Home, Departure, Tension, Resolution. The ii-V-I completes this journey in just 3 chords.

THE UNIVERSAL HARMONIC ARC



THE 4 CADENCES — WHERE THE ARC BREAKS OR COMPLETES

AUTHENTIC

V → I

Arc completes fully. Stage 3 → Stage 4. Strongest resolution possible.

PLAGAL

IV → I

Arc skips tension. Stage 2 → Stage 4. Gentle, "Amen" feeling — no tritone pressure.

HALF

any → V

Arc pauses on tension. Lands on Stage 3. Question mark — listener waits for resolution.

DECEPTIVE

V → vi

Arc twists. Goes to Tonic alternate (vi) instead of I. Plot twist — feels like home but darker.

THE MOST EFFICIENT COMPLETE JOURNEY



"The ii-V-I is the most efficient complete harmonic journey. Three chords, all three functions, maximum emotional clarity. Everything else in harmony is a variation, elaboration, or extension of this core idea."